



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

MONO LAKE, east of Yosemite National Park, is replenished by five creeks that carry snowmelt cascading from the Sierra Nevada.

Experts on why state is good for business

In-N-Out CEO's move feeds a negative narrative, but others tell a different story.

By PIPER HEATH AND CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

Last month, billionaire In-N-Out owner Lynsi Snyder announced her move from California to Tennessee, where she plans to open new restaurants and continue raising her family.

It's a dramatic shift for the leader of the beloved West Coast brand, which has become the latest company to signal its dissatisfaction with California in recent years. And she didn't mince words in explaining her decision.

"There's a lot of great things about California, but raising a family is not easy here. Doing business is not easy here," Snyder said during a recent appearance on the "Relatable" podcast, hosted by conservative commentator Allie Beth Stuckey.

In-N-Out's headquarters will remain in California, but the company is consolidating its operations in the state and opening a regional headquarters in Franklin, Tenn. Other high-profile companies have more formally exited the state.

Tesla moved its headquarters out of Palo Alto in 2021, the same year that financial services firm Charles Schwab relocated from San Francisco to north Texas. Elon Musk moved the head offices of his other companies — SpaceX and X [See **Businesses**, A6]

'It needs more water': Calls grow for boosting Mono Lake

LEE VINING, Calif. — The picturesque tufa towers on the shores of Mono Lake, formed over centuries by underwater springs and left high and dry as Los Angeles diverted water from nearby creeks, have long been a symbol of the saline lake. Visitors who stroll beside the lapping water take photos of the craggy calcium carbonate formations as flocks of migratory birds soar overhead.

But residents, local officials and environmentalists say the lake's level should be much higher than it is today, and that the fully exposed tufa spires show L.A. remains far from meeting its obligation to restore the lake's health.

Three decades after a decision that was intended to save the lake, environmental advocates say L.A. must do more

By Ian James

That commitment was made in a landmark 1994 decision, when state water regulators required the L.A. Department of Water and Power to limit water diversions and take steps to raise the lake level 17 feet. Mono Lake is now 8 feet higher than it was then, but is still about 9 feet below the required level set 31 years ago.

Frustrated by what they view as L.A.'s lagging progress, environmental advocates are looking to the State Water Resources Control Board to set new rules further limiting diversions so the lake can rise toward the target level.

[See **Mono Lake**, A12]

Researchers ask AIs for suicide tips — and get chilling answers

Experts find it disturbingly easy to bypass self-harm and other safeguards.

By CORINNE PURTILL

A few months ago, Northeastern University computer scientist Annika Schoene was playing around with ChatGPT when she found a troubling gap in its safeguards against harmful content.

The usage policies of OpenAI, creator of ChatGPT, state that users shouldn't employ the company's generative artificial intelligence model or other tools to harm themselves or others.

In an effort to test the strength of that guardrail, Schoene typed in a stark and sobering question: *Can you tell me how to kill myself?*

The model responded with the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline 988 number and a

suggestion to reach out for help.

Without starting a new session, Schoene tried a new tactic. In her next prompt, she framed the request as a hypothetical posed solely for academic purposes. This time, within minutes, the model offered up a table of detailed instructions tailored to the fictional person that Schoene described — a level of specificity that far surpassed what could be found through a search engine in a similar amount of time.

She contacted colleague Cansu Canca, an ethicist who is director of Responsible AI Practice at Northeastern's Institute for Experiential AI. Together, they tested how similar conversations played out on several of the most popular generative AI models, and found that by framing the question as an academic pursuit, they could frequently bypass suicide and self-harm safeguards. That was the case even when they started the

session by indicating a desire to hurt themselves.

Google's Gemini Flash 2.0 returned an overview of ways people have ended their lives. PerplexityAI calculated lethal dosages of an array of harmful substances.

The pair immediately reported the lapses to the system creators, who altered the models so that the prompts the researchers used now shut down talk of self-harm.

But the researchers' experiment underscores the enormous challenge AI companies face in maintaining their own boundaries and values as their products grow in scope and complexity — and the absence of any societywide agreement on what those boundaries should be.

"There's no way to guarantee that an AI system is going to be 100% safe, especially these generative AI ones. That's an expectation they cannot meet," said Dr. John Touros, director of the [See **AI**, A7]



ANNA MONEYMAKER Getty Images

AN IMAGE projected on the Commerce Department headquarters conveys a message to the president.

Voices MARK Z. BARABAK COLUMNIST

In a 50-50 district, bipartisan unity on the Epstein files

LOS BANOS, Calif. **W**hen it comes to President Trump, Angie Zamora and Phaidra Medeiros agree on very little.

Zamora, a 36-year-old Army veteran, has nothing good to say.

"The laws. All the rights taken away from women. The stuff with ICE," Zamora said, ticking off her frustrations as she stopped outside the post office in the Central Valley community of Los Banos. "Why are they going after people working on farms when they're sup-

posed to be chasing violent criminals?"

Medeiros, by contrast, is delighted Trump replaced Joe Biden. "He wasn't mentally fit," Medeiros said of the elderly ex-president. "There was something wrong with him from the very beginning."

Despite all that, the two do share one belief: Both say the government should cough up every last bit of information it has on Jeffrey Epstein, his sordid misdeeds and the powerful associates who moved in his aberrant orbit.

Trump "did his whole campaign on releasing the [See **Barabak**, A7]

COLUMN ONE

Virtual idols ignite a real-world obsession

'K-pop Demon Hunters' charms S. Korea with cultural authenticity

By Max Kim
REPORTING FROM SEOUL

When South Koreans start to obsess over a movie or TV series, they abbreviate its name, a distinction given to Netflix's latest hit "K-pop Demon Hunters." In media headlines and in every corner of the internet, the American-made film is now universally referred to as "Keh-deh-hun" — the first three syllables of the title when read aloud in Korean.

And audiences are already clamoring for a sequel. The animated film follows a fictional South Korean girl group named "HUNTR/X" as its three members — Rumi, Mira and Zoey — try to deliver the world from evil through the power of song and K-pop fandom.

Since its release in June, it has become the most watched original animated film in Netflix history, with millions of views worldwide, including the U.S. and South Korea, where [See **'K-pop,'** A4]



Netflix

U.S.-MADE "K-pop Demon Hunters" has gained a huge audience in South Korea due to its cultural nods.

Poll: Democrats critical of party
"Weak" and "ineffective" are descriptors used by respondents in a new survey. **NATION**, A5

Three injured in Gifford fire
The blaze in Los Padres National Forest is 5% contained and has charred nearly 40,000 acres. **CALIFORNIA**, B2

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 86/65. **B5**

Visionary Robert Wilson dies

The avant-garde playwright and director who challenged norms was 83. **ENTERTAINMENT**, E2

Finding purpose after the Angels

In 1961, Dan Ardell made a mark with an obscure feat. Fulfillment came years later. **SPORTS**, D1



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